

The Third Option

Near the end of the week. Plan on forty-five minutes. Keep it. You'll bring a piece of it to your Integration and Next-Step Session.

This journal takes one real interaction from the week and walks it through the moves: the two options the trap offered you, the trade you were about to make, the third option, and the one honest sentence you could still say, or could say next time. The goal isn't to have handled it perfectly. It's to see where the opening was, and to write the words.

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

Five minutes of breath. Five in, seven out. When you've arrived, open your eyes and begin.

1. THE MOMENT

One real interaction from this week where the old pull was there. Who was it, and what got triggered. Two or three sentences. Not the whole story. Just enough to bring it back into the room.

2. THE BODY NOW

Close your eyes and let the moment come back. Drop into the body. Where is something present right now, and what's its quality? Pleasant, unpleasant, or neutral? Report what's there, not what you remember.

3. THE TWO OPTIONS

When you're in fight or flight, it seems like there are only two options. Fuck you, or roll over. Succumb or defend. Acquiesce or escalate. Shut down, or pick a fight.

What were the two the trap offered you in this moment, in your own words? Which one did you take, or almost take?

4. THE TRADE

Part of you wanted to stay connected. Another part knew what it was about to give up to do that. What were you trading? Your honesty, your time, your need, your rest, your dignity? Say it plainly. Then go back into the body and feel the cost of that trade. You can even exaggerate it for a moment, so you really feel what it takes.

5. THE THIRD OPTION

The third option is being with: I feel this, and I can respond from there, without cutting off from myself and without cutting off from them. It doesn't have to be dramatic, and it doesn't have to be nothing.

Even if you only see it now, in hindsight: what could staying with yourself and with them have looked like in that moment? Waiting? One clean question? Saying less? Saying the true thing?



6. THE SENTENCE

Write the actual words. One honest sentence, one boundary, or one request. Not “can you not do that.” What you do want, so they could see it in their own mind’s eye. If you said it already, write what you said. If you didn’t, write what you could still say, or could say next time.

Then say it out loud, once, and notice what the body does as you hear it.



7. WHAT COMES NEXT

Once you say what's true, there's a next step: a small agreement about how you'll handle it going forward, so the relationship stops requiring the old performance. What's the small agreement you'd ask for?

8. REGARDLESS OF HOW THEY RESPOND

You may find they can't meet you. Having said it anyway shows your nervous system that you can stand up for what you value and still hold your ground. What would it mean to you to have said it, whatever they do with it?

CLOSING THE WEEK

What's one thing you're taking with you from this week?

What's an open question you're left with?